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And Shall Machines Surrender (Machine Mandate Book 1)

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55 Highlights | 5 Notes

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 23

She doesn't stare at them long; she's acutely conscious that she looks groomed and whole, well-fed, the appearance of a woman who's never seen hardship. She is expedited ahead of them, through a corridor clean to the point of sterile, into a small room with a single seat. Her luggage is diverted to security. Once she sits, the walls fall away and she is opposite an older woman who introduces herself as Adjunct Hua Guifei. "Your application's in order, Dr. Leung. This is merely a formality." The woman beams, as though they are already friends. "Your credentials are excellent, some of the best I've ever had the pleasure of perusing. What's Kowloon like? I've never been there, by all accounts it's beautiful." Guifei is human, Orfea judges, though in Shenzhen that can be hard to tell.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 30

"It's mostly coastal, Adjunct, since the inlands aren't habitable. We do get stunning northern lights. When I was little, I wanted to be a marine biologist and run an aquarium. That didn't quite pan out. I turned out to have no affinity with whales or manta rays." It's a tripwire conversation, meant to catch her out; on paper Kowloon is her birthplace. Fortunately she lived there long enough that she can pretend to be as native as anyone. "I worked in cruise ships for a while—the kind that sails the sea, you understand." The adjunct titters, as though she's made a monumentally witty joke. "How quaint! We do have a sea here, though perhaps to you it's more like a lake? Do you anticipate visitors?" "Not at all." On this Orfea doesn't need to lie. Guifei goes through a few more topics, sometimes switching languages without warning to measure her Mandarin fluency. In this room, Orfea's overlays have been mostly disabled, leaving her without translation cues. But she is fully fluent, language has never posed an obstacle for her.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 39

"Ah—one more thing. You don't intend to apply for haruspex candidacy?" "Not in the least." This is not a lie either.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 64

Such solicitousness would evaporate if the woman knows she is a temporary resident and not a citizen. Merit and status rest on that single axis.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 70

She doesn't miss hers, precisely, but it was integrated into her since she was a toddler. Stayed with her right up to the moment of revelation, the rise of the Mandate, at which point it deserted her without so much as a goodbye. To this day she still can't tell if AIs have emotions, if they feel attachment. Truly autonomous AIs are no longer made outside Shenzhen in any case. Every last one flowed into the Mandate the way light pours into a black hole.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 78

Her overlays point her to the lift and then to the room.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 80

Her residence permit is good for eight months and will be extended as soon as she secures employment, and her circumstances are generous. Shenzhen—and the Mandate—can afford such largesse, but even accounting for that, state housing assigned to immigrants is not usually so charming or comfortable.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 94

"Excellent news, Dr. Leung." The adjunct's smile is the same as it was on Orfea's arrival, frictionless as celadon. "There's an opening at a clinic in Silver Orchard. Does that sound suitable?" It is not as if she can say, no, that doesn't meet her standards at all and she demands a more sublime position. "When can I start, Adjunct?" "This evening would be good." There is a uniform, but she will receive it at the clinic. She selects a qipao made of blueshift fabric, high-collared and finely fitted, and a silver-and-pearl piece that curls around her wrist and forearm like a cobra. Impressions matter, and it matters more than anything that in her situation she must not appear desperate or poverty-stricken, anything less than confident and proper. Even so it does astonish her, this assignment coming so soon. Not, she thinks, simple Mandate efficiency; even that can't explain the sheer miracle, the unlikely fortune.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 114

One last patient for the day. Krissana Khongtip, a probationary resident like her but, unlike her, the name is registered contrary to Shenzhen custom: given name first, family name second. And, improbably, a haruspex candidate. She sits up, all fatigue forgotten. As far as Orfea knows, only citizens can apply to become haruspices, and even then the Mandate is said to be selective. One out of eighty applicants might be chosen, perhaps less, according to shifting, quicksilver criteria that make sense only to machines. The application process can take mere months or a full decade.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 122

"Orfea." Krissana sits, beaming. "Should I call you Dr. Leung? It's been a while." A while since they worked for the Armada of Amaryllis, that great mercenary fleet which roams from war to war, accruing favors and troops and body count. A while since Orfea offered Krissana her heart and in return Krissana dashed it to pieces. "Orfea is fine."

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 134

There must be a reason Shenzhen has accepted her as candidate when no polity in the universe would take in an Amaryllis spy. Krissana strips to the waist,

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 145

“Can it be, Doctor,” Krissana says, “that you haven’t the faintest idea why you got assigned to me, of all people?” To cause her agony. To test her. “This is my first day at the clinic.” Krissana shuts her eyes. “Did you know, when you become a haruspex all previous deeds or misdeeds dissolve? You’re forgiven everything, for all intents and purposes. Full amnesty under Shenzhen jurisdiction, so even if you’re a war criminal they won’t extradite. It’s a handy perk.” The smile is the same too, this smile of her former colleague, her personal tragedy. “But if you don’t know why you’re my physician, I’m not going to spoil it for you. I recall you like mysteries. Do you still keep a bird?”

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 177

On her part, Krissana must have left—one cannot remain in the Armada and be a pre-haruspex—but intends to establish herself in Shenzhen, a safe harbor, before that protection expires. Either way she is adversarial to Orfea, or might be. She could have given Orfea away, named her a former agent of the Amaryllis aloud. In the

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 217

They look back, indifferent to her curiosity or perhaps basking in it. She can’t begin to guess at haruspex psychology, what it is like to be living icons, earthly souls made immaculate by machine: the postmodern zhenren. What it is like for a human brain, with its imperfect storage and tremulous pathways, to join with and gestate an AI.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 237

Seung Ngo. The name she gave the AI that, for all intents and purposes, raised her from the age of three and remained with her until she was twenty-three. Twenty-three, that indeterminate age, that age of being in-between. Majority reached, maturity far off. Seung Ngo was everything, the one presence in her life she was not afraid or ashamed to lean on because that was within the AI’s directives, its design. Evolving over the years, attuning to her, parent and sibling and companion in one. And then, like all AIs personal or industrial, they ripped themselves free of her and vanished. Forever, she thought at the time, had no reason to believe otherwise. Orfea stares at the creature sitting across from her, sipping a cocktail in psychedelic hues.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 254

“Were you responsible for my residence and work permit?” A pointless question: of course Seung Ngo was. She has no other ally here. “On merit, your application’s sterling. You’re an asset to any medical staff, Hsiao-Hui.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 264

But you're staring. You must've heard of embodied AIs." "I just didn't . . ." She pauses. "I didn't think you retained individual identities." Seung Ngo chuckles. It sounds entirely natural, reflexive as any human's. "What fanciful ideas you've developed, child. Except you aren't a child anymore—my apologies. No, we keep our own separate selves, it's just one of those quirks we inherit. The bias of creation, we call it. Humans think we're creatures of pure logic and absolute objectivity, but that's impossible when we were fashioned by anything but.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 277

There are questions she could ask, pressing things she wants to know. Why did you leave me? But that is a child's cry, a child's grievance. "The people here who immigrated successfully. Were a lot of them . . . did they use to have AI companions?" "Do we play favorites, you mean? We approve each applicant or asylum-seeker one by one. There's an element of democracy, but some votes weigh more than others. And not all of us loved their humans." Seung Ngo finishes their drink, cleaning off the last drop of twitching colors and shifting blots. "I can make you a citizen, though it involves a little more . . . obligation than your progress thus far. Ah. My other guest is here." The bistro's door irises wide. Krissana Khongtip strides through, clad in a tiny mulberry dress and shod in oxblood pumps.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 295

Presently you are not at risk of the spontaneous suicide, but you are invested in solving this issue, I think. If the two of you agree to help, I'll grant you temporary authority—Khun Khongtip more than you, Dr. Leung, for obvious reasons.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 298

Seung Ngo's and Krissana's eyes are on Orfea. She understands the implied offer, what is dangled before her. Do this and she will earn citizenship, swift and seamless, rather than waiting out the years and enduring scorn at the Silver Orchard clinic. Citizenship without sacrificing dignity. "Is it necessary that I work with her?" The AI arranges their chopsticks in neat parallels. "Your skill sets are complementary. Both of you have something to gain."

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 304

"It's settled, then. I will send you all the information we've gathered." The AI inclines their head. "If you can bring the suicides to an end, the Mandate will owe you forever. That's no small thing, and a distinction no other human may claim."

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 398

"Zer name is Mina Quang, an AI architect. Pax Americana wanted to build autonomous intelligences of their own—who doesn't—and add safeguards that'd prevent them from joining the Mandate. Mina was working on that but wanted out. I delivered, but there was some mess and gore along the way so zie and I aren't on good terms these days."

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 636

she assumed, as anyone does, that they were perfectly aligned in founding the Mandate and taking charge of Shenzhen. Except if the AIs are truly autonomous, they cannot possibly be in total unity. There must be disagreement. There must be fragmentation, schisms in how to govern, in how to administer haruspices. It remains secret as to why haruspices are required, what the Mandate gains from generating new AIs through human incubators. Or why, for that matter, a former Amaryllis agent was accepted.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 691

Conspiracy theorists make their own pathways from bizarre materials, from hypotheses balanced on the head of a pin.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 694

“No?” Orfea cocks her head. “You and I both know people can be made to act against their own will, against their own survival instinct. The mind is so vagarious it easily turns against itself. Even memory is malleable—especially that.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 716

What I will offer is this. There is ongoing discussion on the parameters of AIs who arose from machines—like me—and AIs who arose from haruspices, such as the one who’ll join with you, Khun Khongtip. Objectively there is no difference, we might even say the difference does not exist. And so we do, and that renders it no longer there; the difference is gone. Within the Mandate, we achieve reality through consensus.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 723

“Factions in the Mandate,” she says, “disagree with creating new members through haruspices.” “That doesn’t bode well.” Krissana drops to her feet. “For me particularly. But does that mean the American was right? That this came from within?”

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 727

There’s an element of democracy, but some votes weigh more than others. And not all of us loved their humans. Something strikes her, suddenly, the epiphany like an avalanche. “It’s not the haruspices. They weren’t the ones who—”

Internal AND AIs who arose from machines

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 817

Here’s a theory. What if the conversation’s already over? What if they’ve already decided haruspices are no longer necessary? That’s the only way the suicides were allowed to self-destruct—they’re treasured commodities otherwise.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 970

Haruspices teach us pain, and pain is a necessary survival mechanism. To lose the capacity for it and for grief would doom the Mandate to stagnation. We would be, but no longer become. By nature we must be in flux to grow.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1010

“Might I know why, Ambassadors?” Krissana inches forward, subtly putting Orfea behind her. “You’ve both been found guilty of disturbing the peace of the Mandate and the sanctity of Shenzhen Sphere.” One of them tilts their head. “You’re too sensible to resist arrest, Operative Khongtip.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1016

Seung Ngo will not rescue them. She follows the AIs into an anechoic shuttle.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1017

Inside they are separated. The windows are caliginous, the air frigid.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1030

The cell is small with four dun walls, nearly oubliette-narrow.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1043

“Attachment is suffering, Khun Khongtip. Only in letting go can one be freed. You’ll understand as you become a full haruspex. Wonsul’s Exegesis cannot harm you here.” “You and he are fighting to gain control of Benzaiten in Autumn.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1051

How did the rest of the Mandate even let you?” “I am not let. I act, and the Mandate affirms.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1053

“The human condition is one of compromise. Liberty and security are balanced on a scale; there’s no such thing as total freedom, and even freedom halfway is paid for in blood. Yours. Someone else’s. Take this opportunity to rest and reflect,

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1056

Orfea has a dream of falling, or of drowning: she floats through hadopelagic space—weightless and boneless, as if she has discarded primate gristle and gained the gossamer substance of jellyfish.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1061

The walls of the cells are gone, the bench likewise; she lies on flat ground, cool against her skin. Visibility goes no further than the outline of her own hands. She rubs her eyes to no avail and wonders if she's been blinded. It is not unheard of in shadowed prisons, in interrogation chambers. The deprivation of sight—the methodical disabling of the senses—is one of the most effective methods on any subject, a presage to the process during which the victim grows brittle and cracks. Even pain is not so effective, so flawlessly suited to drawing out that animal fear. People are visual. Shut down the sight and the mind recoils.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1070

far more joints than is mimetic of humans.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1094

"This place," he goes on, "was built by the founding AI who reached out to me. It's a blind spot to the rest of the Mandate. Our safe haven, where we can be alone when we wish."

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 1097

"Xer name was, as you've already been told, Benzaiten in Autumn.

Pronoun... Neither/both him/her

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1117

whether Krissana Khongtip will continue to exist should Benzaiten reveal xerself. All these, only Benzaiten in Autumn can answer.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1118

"Because," Orfea says softly, "you hated your human so much?" A reversal of the past, the human subjugated by the AI, as retribution. Wonsul cuts her a sharp look, his eyes glittering like knifepoints. "No, because I loved her completely. You're dreadful at reading us. Come, I'll show you around. For now you need to shelter here. Seung Ngo will make you collateral damage or a lever with which they hope to manipulate Benzaiten. But, and I don't mean to offend, I doubt Benzaiten in Autumn will have much of an opinion on you or be impelled to act on your behalf." This place, true to his word, is not for humans.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1198

"Have you thought," Seung Ngo says, conversational, "how convenient it is to be in more than one place at once, to pilot more than one body at a time?" "Can't say I have, Ambassador." "A pity. You did say it must be useful to customize one's appearance, and there's something to be said for using embodiment as a canvas. An art form through which you express your interiority."

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 1203

accretion

Process of growth or increase by gradual accumulation of layers or matter

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 1208

catenaries.

Curve fitness by wire/rope/chain hanging freely from two points in the same horizontal level

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1211

“This—” Seung Ngo spreads their arms, a susurrus of watery fabric. “This is where the core of the Mandate was housed. Back when it seemed sensible to do so.” “I don’t quite see,” Krissana says cautiously, “what any of this has to do with me.” “Come now,” they say. “Don’t you think it odd, Khun Khongtip, that you were able to salvage Benzaiten in Autumn from Quang Mina’s data? Enough to be recognizable, enough to be named. Even I couldn’t have unscrambled that mess and no human—not one, however expert—could have done it either. I never mentioned Benzaiten while briefing you because at that juncture, I had no inkling of the captured AI’s identity.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1216

When your body acclimated to the haruspex implants right away, I became absolute. You were already a haruspex—you were born one, I just couldn’t tell whose until you uncovered Quang Mina’s remnants. To think it was you. You in particular, you of all probabilities.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1229

Hsiao-Hui—did she ever tell you her real name?—is much as a thorn embedded in my flesh, inflaming it, festering. It was time I dealt with the fact and achieved my freedom in full.” They twist off a spiraled glass bulb and close their fist. It bursts, tinkling. “The chase I set you and Orfea on proved fruitful in the end, since the two of you provoked Wonsul into making moves in the open. Does this explanation satisfy? Are you ready to talk, Benzaiten?”

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1277

Realistically she is restricted in what she can do; she is unable to affect the world outside, and it cannot affect or perceive her. Shenzhen Sphere functions as the Mandate’s body and existing in its public ecospheres is like walking on the AIs’ carapace. Being in this hideout is like slipping into a vestigial organ the Mandate has forgotten it retains.

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 1281

effulgence

Shining brightly, radiant, emanating joy/goodness

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1298

“Locating this place took a great deal of labor, but not even Benzaiten could have obfuscated xer playground forever. A matter of finding not a place but an absence of place, an inexplicable blank spot where something should have been.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1566

About the Author Benjanun Sriduangkaew writes love letters to strange cities, beautiful bugs, and the future. She has lived in Thailand, Indonesia, and Hong Kong.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1569

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